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The Truth Takes Time.

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FROM THE EDITORS *Welcome to the March 2024 edition of Voice Express. Our correspondents bring you the stories that matter — from frontlines of policy to quiet revolutions in culture and science.*

CULTURE

Tokyo Thrift: Embracing the Strange Individualisation of the Sustainable Fashion Problem

On why blaming the individual consumer for fast fashion's damage is a structural trap — and what a more honest, less guilt-driven approach to sustainable choices might actually look like when the industry's harms are genuinely systemic.

BY DHAIRYA MISHRA

On derationalising the guilt of individual consumption & finding the middle ground between waiting around for big changes & making small ones happen.

The ugly truth of fast fashion hides behind the glitter and glamour of the social media posts of a generation that does not wish to repeat an outfit. The OOTD (Outfit of the Day) is turning into DOTD (Disaster of the Decade) (I think I'm funny).

Imagine a little child toiling away in a factory for long hours under OSHA-certified 'hazardous' conditions, in order to satisfy your need for quick & cheap clothes. Consider the degree of damage caused when plastic waste from polyester factories enters the stomachs of threatened sea turtles. The impact that our choices in clothing have on the world around us is heartbreaking.

But they are choices , after all. We can always make different ones.

First: Scrap the Guilt

Our sociological collective has a problem with denialism, of shifting blame from all the places it need to be back to the unitary, powerless individual that doesn't even have the authority to refuse it. And I do wish it goes to therapy sometime soon, for its sake if not mine, but it doesn't change the fact that something is better than nothing, & for the while that Gates & Bezos refuse to do their parts, I would like to do something other than crying with my thumb up my ass.

So there's the (multi)billion-dollar question: if it comes down to it, is there a way for us puny, insignificant, middle-class individuals to undo, even in fraction, some of the damage that's being done to the bigger picture? You're one microscopic cog in his catastrophic plan, designed & directed by his red right hand, yada yada, understood. Is there a way, at least, for us to wash our hands clean?

Rich Dad Poor Dad

Of course, one of the larger ways in which a consumer can exercise supposed 'agency' in the market, is his investment choices; & the implication here should be clear enough: if you don't have capital to invest, you don't have capital to make ethical decisions. Beggars, choosers, & all that jazz. So another requisite to understand here, as will be discussed below, is privilege. The obligation to make good choices as a consumer comes with what is first, the privilege to make choices at all. So it should be understood hereon that advice on where within the fashion sector you should invest & on what is less Rich Dad Poor Dad finance guru talk & more The Good Place perspectives on ethical consumption.

<https://www.instagram.com/reel/C4wHtaQyMOu/?igsh=NHl3MjB3NzAoZjM5>

Bad Advice Can Be Good Advice

Start by deciding on eco-friendly and sustainable materials that are less or just not harmful to the environment, such as organics like cotton, hemp, or recycled textiles. It may sound elementary, but sticking it out with the good old organics can be a deceptively effective way to decrease one's reliance on quick fashion. Think about how many t-shirts you've gone through in the last 5 years versus how many your parents did when you were growing up. How many did your grandparents? A good organic polyblend will last longer ; the point of buying a 1000-dollar jacket may not be a wise expenditure in any economic pool of thought outside of Shark Tank, but it can be to minimize the resources exhausted in the making of the alternative five.

Think about it - fast fashion is like fast food. It might be cheaper at a time, but absurdly more expensive & wasteful put together as long-term expenditures, thereby trapping lower income groups in a vicious cycle that coerces them to take part in the very consumption patterns that drain them, both ethically & financially.

If you've got the money, eat a salad, & wear cotton, not only because you can, but because doing so is the only way to ensure you won't need to down the line, either. There's many a survivor of unHappy meals who will resent you a little less for using your privilege right.

Think about it, fast fashion is like fast food. It might be cheaper at a time, but absurdly more expensive & wasteful put together during long-term expenditures, thereby trapping lower income groups in a vicious cycle that coerces them to take part in the very consumption patterns that drain them, both ethically & financially. Dhairya Mishra, Uniting for a Sustainable Fashion Future: The Power of Collective Action

— DHAIRYA MISHRA, UNITING FOR A SUSTAINABLE FASHION FUTURE: THE POWER OF COLLECTIVE ACTION

Checking Your Investments: 5 Minute Crafts

Thirty different audiences & thirty different looks for them to look at. And if all that sounds like a bit much, throw it back in the bin.

If you get bored even thinking about it thirty times, you have no business taking it home.

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Werk, bitch.

Not only should we choose our clothing carefully, but we need to style it well. Yes, you heard that right, all those Pinterest style videos pinned up on your autumn aesthetics board & Instagram style reels clogging up your saves are weapons in your climate fashion war & a soft cottage core girl will inherit the earth. Keep up.

Jokes aside, it's important to remember that the villain is not fashion here. The villain is industry. The villain is mass production without regulation, & mass consumption without thought. When the title says sustainable fashion, it does still mean fashion. Reread the first section again if you must, but don't forget, you are not where the blame lies. If the world goes down in flames 5 decades from now it will not be because a young girl with seemingly vain tastes wanted to dress up cute.

Your joys are not killing the world. You can want to look good, & you can want to spend time & resources on doing so. But being thoughtful about techniques can help minimise the amount of resources that go to waste, & the argument becomes simple: if your looks are entirely dependent on the money you spend on them, you're not fashionable, you're just rich.

A single article of clothing can be dressed in a variety of ways to produce various looks, which can help the garment last longer and decrease waste. The point is, you don't have to look up a list of sustainable fashion influencers to be sustainable, even just putting a bit more effort into doing fashion right can be sustainable.

Tokyo Thrift: Macklemore Them Tags Swades Conclusion

Congratulations, you made it. So, to conclude, depending on where in the world it is that you're shopping, it can be more or less sustainable to buy expensive or cheap. (Fascinating how that can happen. It's almost as if one needs to look at who one is paying & what for, along with how much.)

It's important to understand that the key takeaway here is not to consume in a way that is completely ethical (if you've either seen The Good Place or studied higher economics, (two equivalent philosophical qualifications) you might be familiar with the fact that that isn't quite possible) but simply more ethical than all viable alternatives.

"We do not need a handful of people doing zero waste perfectly. We need millions of people doing it

GENDER Women's College Infirmary Charges Five Rupees Per Pad; Automatic Dispensers Charge Ten

At Kalindi College — a Delhi University institution that calls itself all-women's and teaches courses in feminist theory — the medical infirmary charges students five rupees per sanitary pad. A ground report on the gap between institutional pride and the institutional care actually on offer.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Excessive control & a resource-precious attitude make Kalindi College's medical infirmary functionally redundant.

February 25, 2023, New Delhi: On 8 March 1914, the arrest of Sylvia Pankhurst was the domino that tipped the way to the celebration of International Women’s Day today. Over a century later, things are little more than marginally better, and the consolation we get is that at least they’re 'changing.' And slowly but surely, it seems they are. Urban women’s lives have lost all identifiable traces of the barbaric pasts that unfortunately still cling to many. Yet there are some fundamental structures of our society, the very institutions that were meant to be the flag bearers of this change - lead the way, so to speak - that are perhaps holding it back. In Delhi University's Kalindi College, one that takes great pride in calling itself an all-women’s institution (one that boasts of being one of what are DU’s handful of institutions that have a media department, & in it countless courses has countless readings on gender, society & feminist theory), an individual sanitary napkin at the already ill-equipped & resource-fond infirmary incurs students a cost of a loud, dumbfounding 5 rupees. Decisions like these are what make the Pink Tax so pervasive & inescapable in modern societal structures. The average ranges of Whisper & Stayfree napkins, two of India’s most popular brands & also the most commonly stocked in colleges like Kalindi, are priced at rupees Rs. 26-29 for the one-week packs, i.e. Rs. 4 per pad. Charging students a single rupee more, therefore neither subsidises this cost for them nor makes any significant contribution towards recovering let alone profiting off of it. The only purpose it serves, is to discourage students from using a facility that is meant to be for them.

A ‘Well-Equipped’ Room: Shell Facilities in Government Institutes

“My friend was on her period the other day, and so I'd gone to grab her a pad from the infirmary. I was charged 5 rupees for the napkin. The incident was stupefying in a way. It is not just about the amount you have to pay but the fact that you have to pay at all,” says Shruti Patel, a senior at Kalindi & Head of Design at TVE. “You don't expect there to be a fee on a pad in a college 'medical room.” “It's degrading,” added another student. Interestingly, this resource-precious attitude is not limited to sanitary napkins, but extends to the entire facility of what Kalindi College's website describes as a ‘well-equipped medical room [where] the college provides good medical facility to students & staff.’ Students are forced to purchase basic first aid items like band-aids & gauze from pharmacies outside the campus or exaggerate difficulties to be provided any help at the infirmary. “I remember my ankles being scraped raw the day of our NCC fest. I went to the medical room hoping to get some gauze or anything for relief, but all they gave me was one band-aid. The nurse said she wouldn’t give me even a second one unless I showed her blood,” says Manasvi Vats, the JUO of Udaan, Kalindi College’s NCC. Manasvi tells us she had to call up her friend to bring her band-aids from home instead. They cost 2 rupees. Dr. Rajshree Lal of the medical staff remains available for attending students and staff for their ‘minor complaints’ for three hours every alternate day of the week. The remaining time, the room is under the management of Ms. Rekha, who visits the college every day from 9 AM to 5 PM. Most students know the medical room as synonymous with nurse Rekha, a smiling, kind-faced woman who would rather the cleaning staff do her dirty work for her, both literally & otherwise, as the following account from a senior who would rather remain anonymous describes. “I remember having a fever of around 100 one time back in my first year. I somehow managed to drag myself to the medical room in between classes - & this was nearly noon, so the heat was severe - & it was closed. The door was bolted. I looked around, I

POLITICS

'I am the Head of my Household, He is the Head of India’s': How Narendra Modi Earned the Favour of the Indian Middle Class

Manoj Jangra — CRPF retiree and family business owner in South-West Delhi — explains, in his own words, why he supports Narendra Modi. A ground-level portrait of the political convictions and disappointments that built, and continue to sustain, the BJP's urban middle-class base.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Manoj Jangra, a small business owner in New Delhi’s Dwarka, & a CRPF retiree tells us why he likes Modi, & you should too.

Paintings & bulk posters bought wholesale from Sadar Bazaar line the walls of the shop; Ram Vivah Pose A, Ram Vivah Pose B, Shiv Vivah (a rarity), Lakshmi Ganesh Sitting Pose (‘Seated Gods are good luck’). Along with online orders of album posters & lyric art, the things that sell the most at their shop are Gods.

Mr. Jangra opened this shop back in 2014, after becoming disillusioned with the government institutions he was working for during the Lokpal Protests. If you ask him why he quit his job at the CRPF, he has a very clear answer. “Because of Kejriwal,” he says.

“At the time there was Congress at the center, & the corruption was suffocating. There was no end to it. I wasn’t even working for the government anymore, I was just working for individuals, all of them corrupt. Kejriwal used to speak so well. He fought the government fearlessly. He was so bold, he said he would pass the Lokpal bill, end the disparity. That these officers won’t travel as VIPs anymore. They will be like us. I was very moved by his promises. I fell for them.”

Today, thirteen years after the people of India took to the streets to fight Congress’ rule of corruption, the Lokpal protests remain a testament to the power of public dissent. The roar of a nation, following the voice of a small, insignificant man. Arvind Kejriwal’s words were powerful enough to move Manoj Jangra to reject a life of civil service, security, & a salary.

Pros & Cons: ‘Achchhaiyan Bhi Toh Ginwao.’

“ Bohot hi negative way me lejata hai cheezon ko. Har cheez mei burai. Kabhi achhaia bhi toh ginwao.” (“He is too negative about everything. Always recounting criticisms. One should take into account positives too.”) Mr. Jangra does not believe it is reasonable to be so robustly

" Road dekho. Bahar bahar ke nahi, bahar bahar ke toh theek kara dete hai, kyunki whaan se toh ye netaon vagehra ki gaadiyan jayengi. Yahan jahan aam janta rehta hai, kitne kharaab kar rakhe hai. Meri scooty raise hi tooti this. Ab gareeb aadmi ko farak nahi padta, road kaisa ho. Toh ye kuchh nahi karte ." (“Look at the roads. Not the main ones, of course, the main ones are all fixed up, that’s where the ministers & the big men drive. But the ones here where ordinary men like me live, the roads are terrible. My scooty broke because of roads like these. But the poor don’t care about roads. So they do nothing.”)

On being asked to elaborate on what some examples of the purported good that the Central Government has done may be, though, his eyes light up. Contrary to what now under arrest Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal observed in his 2019 interview with Kunal Kamra, BJP supporters like Manoj Jangra do have an answer to the question (of just why it is that they like Mr. Narendra quite so much), & they have thought about it plenty.

What, Over the Past 10 Years, Should We be Grateful For?

“Ji pehli cheez toh hai security. Aaj se 10 saal pehle Dilli mei har jagah, buson mei, metro mei, sab jagah, announcement hote rehte the. ‘Kisi anjaan vastu ko na chhuye isme bum ho sakta hai.’Aaj kal sunai deti hai kahin?” (“The first thing is security. 10 years ago you could hear announcements in Delhi, in the buses, metros, everywhere: ‘Don't touch unidentified objects, they may contain bombs.’ Do you hear them nowadays?”)

“Isme check karne ka kya hai? Maine khud dekha hai apni aankhon se.” (“What is there to check? I've seen it with my own eyes.”)

Confident observations like these are what form the basis of much of the politics of Mr. Jangra, as well as that of most ordinary Indians. This striking affinity for reason, logic, & critical thinking is characteristic of the Right Wing Indian - he does not believe in books, facts, or numbers. He believes only in what can be understood with logic. He believes only in his own observations, which he also believes he arrives at independently. After all, there is no evidence more damning than an eyewitness testimony.

In 2019, upon receiving complaints about the oversaturation of announcements on the Magenta Line, the DMRC announced that it would do away with 25 unessential announcements, & only 7 important ones would stay in place inside the trains. ‘Security’ announcements like bomb alerts are the first of

tried to ask people, but there was no one & I was doing so poorly that eventually, I couldn't wait anymore. I thought I'd at least get inside, and sit down; I was on the verge of passing out. So I unbolted the door & sat down & there was so much immediate relief, getting off my feet & out of the heat. I must have waited for - what, at least another 15 minutes, before anyone came. I was so happy I thought I'd finally get something, anything, even just a Crocin, some damn electrolytes, whatever they'd give me, at that point, I'd be grateful. But turns out it was just someone from the cleaning staff who'd noticed the door was open. She came in & started interrogating me, chastising me for presuming to let myself in, implying I may have vandalised the room & god knows what else. She stayed till the nurse arrived, which was another 15 minutes later, but she made it very clear it wasn't out of any real concern for my well-being, just 'keeping watch'. By the time the nurse arrived, I was already sufficiently distracted from the fever by the third degree. She silently watched as the woman berated me for another long while, not just condoning but appreciating what had happened before finally asking me what was wrong. She gave me a small paracetamol tablet & made me sign in the register. I've never gone to the medical room since." The authorities' description of the room & its capabilities make it clear that they do not exceed beyond being able to provide extremely elementary medical aid to students for their, in their own words, 'minor inconveniences.' So, the refusal of medical staff to then entertain & treat what inconveniences they do deem as minor, beg the question what purpose, if any, this facility serves at all. Accounts like the ones above are reflected in the tired resignation found in the two demographics most well versed with the medical room, NCC & Sports. "We used to train (march) out in the parking lot during the summers & students would pass out or come close on a near daily basis. If you bring another student to speak for you, the nurse reluctantly gives you glucose or something,

critical of a government, regardless of elections, timing, & party promises. He is in fact afraid, that if the party currently in power should lose, whatever good is being done (little or not) will be lost. If you ask him to reiterate why he doesn't like Kejriwal's work in New Delhi, though, he recounts the things that dissatisfy him.

these seven. But that is neither logic nor reason.
"Mai khud soch nahi sakta kya? " ("Can't I figure it out on my own?")

because they can exaggerate the issue. If you are, say, dehydrated to the point of blacking out, you can get a glass of glucose,” said a senior of Udaan. This is especially egregious in the face of the faculty’s revelation that the only qualified doctor on the premises is only there to treat minor medical issues, transforming these incidents from those of general apathy to legitimate medical malpractice, constantly baiting students to bring them more than they can chew, & refusing to bite what they can. What is most concerning about these incidents is they don’t seem to exist in isolation, but instead stem from a larger culture of institutional incompetence. Aspects of this incompetence can be observed in most government institutions, & Delhi University is no exception, but Kalindi College’s sanitation sees a version of it so extreme that it stands in significant contrast to even other colleges of DU. Indira Gandhi Institute of Physical Education & Sports Sciences is a small, single-department college in Delhi’s Vikaspuri. It is one of the 12 colleges of Delhi University 100% funded by the Delhi Government instead of the centre, & its labs, faculty & academia all suffer from a lack of regular financing. Even here, toilets are clean, & pads are free, as told by Ritu, a first student in the only program offered by the college. So it is not a question of budget, but a question of apathy & intent. Kalindi College, infamous for its mismanagement & regular controversies recently went viral on Instagram due to the abysmal state of its student toilets. Its academic contributions are a long & undulating list of predatory journals & frivolous conventions. It must then be observed that the seeming redundancy of the infirmary is not noteworthy because it is anomalous, but precisely because it isn’t; following along a disturbing pattern of mismanagement at an institute that, despite its A+ NAAC accreditation, is plagued by a lack of seriousness.

He can. And he is welcome to. Upon analysis of terrorism databases & reports by TVE it was found that there is indeed a correlation between terror attacks carried out before 2014 & after, just not the one Mr. Jangra suggests. On the contrary, the top five years in Indian history by number of terrorist incidents, are all from the Modi Regime. But then again, correlation is not causation. And what credibility does the Global Terrorist Database have, anyway, compared to an ex-CRPF officer (Retd. 2014) & a man with three generations' worth of relatives all over India & the world?

When these statistics are quoted to him, he laughs in incredulity, finding them ridiculous.

“You people will believe anything.”

Another of the Modi government’s achievements that makes Mr. Jangra’s chest swell up with pride is the great strides India has made under its tenure in matters of military self-reliance.

“Aaj se das saal pehle tak har cheez import hoti thi. Har hathiyaar. Koi bhi hathiyaar India mei nahi bante the. Aaj dekh lo. Haan jets vagehra toh import karne padte hi hai.” (“10 years ago everything used to be imported, every weapon. No weapon was made in India. Look at us now. Of course, we still have to import things like jets.”)

This Hindustan Times article from 2012 illustrates just how abysmal India’s position in global arms trade was before the Modi government came to power. Today, not only are our import rates lower, but our export rates are higher than ever. Much of this can be accredited to the strategic bans placed on imports of defense items over the last two years, which have now had four iterations. There has been an active push toward indigenisation, spearheaded by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, & it has not come without cost.

Domestic procurement alone in the military budget progressively increased from ₹51,000 crores in 2020 to nearly twice that at ₹1 Lakh crores in 2023 . In contrast, the entire allocation for education in the same budget was ₹1.2 Lakh crores. This colossal jump in expenses is justified as being a temporary measure that will change India’s military dependence & make room for self-reliance, but 12 years & 12 progressively increasing budgets later, we are still the world’s largest importer of arms. We still don’t feature in even the top 25 arms-exporting nations. India’s import rates have gone down from 13% to 9.8%, a 3.2% decrease over 12 years, i.e. just 0.26% a year. The

“Women’s safety dekh lo. Buson mei aurton ke liye free ticketein. Transport. Bijli paani ki suvidhaayein. Bohot kuch badla hai. Bohot kuch behtar hua hai. Jab mai Dilli aaya tha toh hamara sir ke upar bulb tak nahi hota tha. Ham andhere mei rehte the.” (“Look at women's safety. There's free tickets for women in city buses. Transport, water & electricity facilities. Much has changed. Much has improved. When I came to Delhi we didn't even have a lightbulb above our heads. We used to live in the darkness.”)

Notably, free tickets for women in buses, free water & electricity for residential consumption, & last mile connectivity are all initiatives of the Aam Aadmi Party-run Delhi government, that have been taken, incidentally, also in the last 10 years.

When reminded that transport, electricity, & water are jurisdictions of the state government, Mr. Jangra clarifies that he is speaking of improvements made to the nation at large. All of which, at the end of the day, are being made at the helm of the leader of the country: the Prime Minister.

“Ab dekho, apna ghar mai chalata hun. Mere ghar mei kuch bhi achha hoga, meri beti tournament jeetegi ya mera beta afsar banega, toh ye meri bhi achievement hogi. Desh Pradhaan mantri chalata hai.” (“Look, I run my house. An achievement in my house - say, my daughter wins a tournament or my son becomes an officer - is my achievement too. The Prime Minister runs the country.”)

They must be.

When asked to go on listing examples, Mr. Jangra promises to think & find more when he has the time. He hadn’t prepared for a presentation, after all.

In the conversation that follows, the mood is nudged away from the intense & political to lighthearted small talk & chit chat. Now that the procedural part of the interview is over, our correspondent offers commentary of their own on all that’s changed for the better in the Modi regime. A UPI payment card on the table can be seen standing out on the table, bright with colors of the Indian flag; Bharat Interface for Money.

Interestingly, India’s one-of-a-kind UPI system is not a matter of pride to Mr. Jangra. He hardly even believes that Western nations & china did not invent the technology first.

“Haan par America ke paas toh aur pehle se tha, ” (“But America had the tech even earlier.”) he says, unsure, before our correspondent explains that he is confusing e-commerce technology with UPI, a payments interface developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). He laughs, embarrassed, explaining that he is not very well-versed in these things. He doesn’t even have Paytm on his phone & prefers to use cash; the QR codes in his shop are a necessity of the trade. But he accepts our correspondent's praise for the technology with an open mind nevertheless.

She does not mention that the NPCI itself was established back in 2008, & its ownership has since been shared between several promoter banks, mostly private ones, & that Narendra Modi neither funded, initiated, nor endorsed the efforts behind making UPI a success, as he did later on & with RuPay.

Mr. Jangra smiles at the monologue, happy to see that his encouragement to look at the bright side stuck. “Fir log kehte hai vikaas nahi hota.” (“And then people say there isn't development.”)

decrease of our reliance on Russia has been parallelly accompanied by an increase of that on the West. But one must not always be critical.

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